



Aristotle

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INTRODUCTION

Talking about Aristotle is no simple task. His thought is so vast and profound that it can hardly be summarized in a few words. However, we can approach some of his central ideas, especially his reflections on happiness, one of the most relevant themes in his ethical and political philosophy, and the concept of the golden mean.

SPEAKING

Personal Reflections

- What does happiness mean to you personally?
- Can you remember a moment when you felt truly happy? What made it so?
- Do you think happiness is more about inner peace or external circumstances?
- How do you know when you are genuinely happy?

Philosophical and Psychological Views

- Is happiness the same as pleasure or joy, or something deeper?
- Can someone be happy without achieving their goals?
- Do you think happiness depends more on attitude or on life events?
- Is happiness an individual pursuit or a collective experience shared with others?

Happiness in Daily Life

- What small things in daily life bring you happiness?
- How do relationships influence your sense of happiness?
- Do material possessions create lasting happiness, or only temporary satisfaction?
- How important is gratitude in feeling happy?

Broader Perspectives

- Do you think happiness should be life's main goal, or is there something more important?
- Can someone be happy while facing challenges or suffering?
- How does culture shape the way we understand and pursue happiness?
- Is happiness something we can control, or is it more about luck and circumstances?



Two-Person Dialogue Activity: Exploring Happiness

Objective: Help both participants reflect on their personal views of happiness and discover similarities and differences in their perspectives.

Step 1: Warm-Up (2–3 minutes each)

- Question: *When you think of happiness, what is the first image, memory, or feeling that comes to mind?*
- Each person shares without interruption.

Step 2: Personal Sharing Questions (Take turns answering)

- Can you describe a moment when you felt completely happy?
- Do you think happiness comes more from things you do for yourself, or from connections with others?
- What role does gratitude play in your happiness?

Step 3: Reflection and Comparison

- Discuss together: *Are our definitions of happiness similar or different?*
- *Do we believe happiness is something you can create, or something that just happens to you?*

Step 4: Deeper Questions for Debate

Take turns playing “devil’s advocate” to challenge each other’s answers:

- Should the goal of life be happiness, or something else like purpose or contribution?
- Can happiness exist during difficult times, or does it disappear until things improve?

Step 5: Closing Reflection

- Each person answers: *What small choice or action could you make this week to bring more happiness into your life or someone else’s?*



VIDEO



QUIZ

Multiple-choice questions(A, B, C, D):

1. What central theme does Aristotle propose for happiness?
 - A) Pleasure
 - B) Wealth
 - C) A life guided by reason
 - D) Social norms
2. According to the text, happiness is:
 - A) A passive feeling
 - B) A result of luck
 - C) An activity of using and perfecting reason
 - D) Exclusively achieving external success
3. What does the “mean” (the middle) represent in virtue, according to Aristotle?
 - A) An exact mathematical average
 - B) Always leaning toward extremes
 - C) A midpoint between excesses
 - D) A rigid rule applicable to all cases
4. Which virtue is paired with courage as an example?
 - A) Generosity
 - B) Humility C) Patience
 - D) Honesty



5. What is, for Aristotle, the most divine part of the human being?
 - A) The body
 - B) Emotions
 - C) The intellect
 - D) Memory
6. What does “practical wisdom” mean in the context of the text?
 - A) Knowing theories without applying them
 - B) Having emotional intuition
 - C) Knowing when to apply reason to decide the right action
 - D) Following rules without question
7. According to the passage, what is one of the fundamental questions we seek to answer?
 - A) What is the best technology?
 - B) What makes a life worth living?
 - C) How to accumulate wealth quickly?
 - D) How fast can we advance?
8. What is said about the relationship between thinking and human purpose?
 - A) Thinking is irrelevant to happiness
 - B) Happiness comes from avoiding thinking
 - C) Dedicating life to thought and knowledge brings us closer to our purpose
 - D) Thought should be suppressed to live better
9. In the text, what is the risk of having too much courage?
 - A) Cowardice
 - B) Moderation
 - C) Recklessness
 - D) Excessive generosity
10. What is proposed as a possible guide for modern life?
 - A) The extreme end of any ideology
 - B) Emotional law
 - C) The rational mean, or “golden mean”
 - D) Ignoring philosophy and following tradition



ANSWERS

1. C - A life guided by reason

Explanation: Aristotle argues happiness comes from rational activity in accordance with virtue, i.e., living a life guided by reason.

2. C - An activity of using and perfecting reason

Explanation: Happiness is not a passive feeling or luck; it is the result of rational activity and the exercise of virtue.

3. C - A midpoint between excesses

Explanation: The mean is a balance between two extremes—deficiency and excess—relative to the situation and person.

4. C - Patience

Explanation: Courage is often illustrated alongside a complementary virtue like patience; the pair shows balance in action.

5. C - The intellect

Explanation: For Aristotle, the highest (divine) part of the human being is rational intellect.

6. C - Knowing when to apply reason to decide the right action

Explanation: Practical wisdom (phronesis) is about applying reason to determine the appropriate action in given circumstances.

7. B - What makes a life worth living?

Explanation: A key enduring question is what constitutes a life worth living, i.e., the purpose and end of human existence.

8. C - Dedicating life to thought and knowledge brings us closer to our purpose

Explanation: The relationship is that thoughtful understanding and knowledge align us with human telos or purpose.

9. C - Recklessness

Explanation: Excess of virtue-related qualities (e.g., too much courage) leads to reckless behaviour; moderation is key.

10. C - The rational mean, or “golden mean”

Explanation: The proposed guide for modern life is the balanced, rational mean rather than extremes or tradition alone.



SCRIPT

For thousands of years, we've been asking the same big question: how do you live a good life? One of the first, and maybe one of the best, answers ever came from Aristotle. So, what can an ancient Greek philosopher really teach us about finding fulfillment today? Let's start with a question for you and be honest—forget what you think you're supposed to say. What do you really, truly believe is the key to your happiness? Just think about that for a second, because Aristotle had a very specific and probably pretty surprising answer.

Most of us, right? We probably point to things on the left—pleasure, success, making a lot of money. But Aristotle would say we're completely missing the point. He argued that real fulfillment, the deep stuff, isn't found in any of those external things. Nope—it's found inside us, by living a life guided by reason. Okay, so a life of Reason—what is that even mean in practice? Let's break down what Aristotle was really getting at when he talked about true happiness.

See, for Aristotle, happiness isn't some passive feeling you just get from things happening to you. It's an activity; it is the ongoing work of using and perfecting the one thing that makes us uniquely human: our amazing ability to think. And listen to this from the man himself: he believed that dedicating your life to thought and knowledge was literally the highest thing a person could do. He said that by living to our intellect, which he saw as the most divine part of us, we get as close to being Godlike as we possibly can. For him, that was the ultimate purpose of being human.

But of course, we're not just walking brains, right? Now let's make this real with some examples. Take courage: if you have too little of it, you're a coward; if you have too much, you're reckless. The virtue—real courage—is that mean, right in the middle. And you see the same pattern with generosity: it's the perfect balance between being stingy on one side and just wasteful on the other.

Now this is absolutely crucial: this mean is not some simple mathematical average you can just calculate. It's what Aristotle called practical wisdom. So here's the playbook for how you actually use that wisdom in any situation: first, you assess what's going on; second, you apply your reason, not your gut reaction or your raw emotion; and then, from that careful thinking, you determine the right virtuous action—the mean.

And let's be super clear here: excellence 2,500 years ago was simply thinking about all this stuff. Just let that number sink in for a moment. And yet, for all our technology and progress, guess what? We are still wrestling with the exact same fundamental questions: What makes a life worth living? How do I become a good person? How do we build a society? Political extremes—maybe the most courageous, the most radical act of all is to seek that rational, balanced middle ground. Maybe the golden mean is the guide we still desperately need.



READING

HAPPINESS ACCORDING TO ARISTOTLE

From the outset, Aristotle warns us of a first problem: most people are not clear about what it truly means to be happy.

For him, the ultimate end of human beings is precisely happiness, but not understood superficially. Some identify happiness with the enjoyment of physical pleasures, but Aristotle argues that this is a mistake. Others think that happiness consists of achieving success or accumulating wealth, and he does not consider this correct either.

According to Aristotle, true happiness is achieved when a person brings to its maximum perfection that which defines them: their rationality. We are beings endowed with reason, and therefore, living well, having a full and happy life, equates to living rationally.

This means, mostly, dedicating one's life to contemplation and knowledge. Everything else—work, money, prestige, struggle—can also be done by others. The only thing no one can do in our place is think, and it is in the use of reason that a person becomes truly human and unique.

In his work *Nicomachean Ethics*, Aristotle states that perfect happiness lies in the contemplative activity of the intellect, due to its dignity, autonomy, inherent pleasure, and self-sufficiency. If the intellect is the most divine aspect of a person, living in accordance with it brings us closer to the divine, striving to “make ourselves immortal as far as possible.”

THE PURSUIT OF VIRTUE

For Aristotle, being happy also implies being virtuous. The virtuous person is not carried away by impulses or passions but knows how to moderate them with reason. This vision remains relevant today: we live in an era where feelings are often placed above reflection, which ends up producing a kind of social infantilization.

This occurs both in personal life and in politics. Often, political debates are reduced to emotional allegiances, as if they were soccer teams: “I stand with my side because I feel that way.” Aristotle would say that this is insufficient. A society guided solely by immediate emotions does not build true freedom nor make genuine common well-being possible.

ARISTOTLE AND POLITICS

In the political realm, Aristotle shows a certain scepticism toward democracy. He sees it as a system that, without control, risks turning into demagoguery. For him, true freedom does not consist in the absence of laws but in submitting to just laws. Without norms, a person does not live in freedom but in barbarism.

On this point, he agrees with his teacher Plato, who, after writing *The Republic*, ended up defending in *The Laws* the importance of obeying norms, even if the political system was not perfect.

Aristotle also distinguishes between the legal and the legitimate: a ruler may come to power legally but lose legitimacy if they govern thinking only of particular interests or manipulating public opinion. What truly matters is not so much how one attains power but how it is exercised.



For this reason, he proposes a balanced political model, where neither the rich nor the poor govern alone, but the middle classes, capable of maintaining a just mean and avoiding excesses.

THE GOLDEN MEAN

Aristotle develops the idea of the golden mean to explain how virtue is achieved: moral virtue does not consist in choosing extremes (neither excess nor deficiency) but in finding the appropriate balance between the two. This means that, in every situation, a person must seek the intermediate point using reason and prudence.

THE GOLDEN MEAN IN VIRTUE

- Aristotle defines virtue as "a selective disposition, a mean relative to us, determined by reason and by what a prudent person would decide."
- Virtue lies between two vicious extremes: for example, courage is the golden mean between cowardice and recklessness; generosity, between stinginess and extravagance.
- This mean is not strictly mathematical but depends on the situation, the person, and the use of rational deliberation—there is no single measure that applies to everyone, as the "golden mean" is relative and personal.

PRUDENCE AND THE PURSUIT OF BALANCE

- The correct way to determine the golden mean is through prudence or *phronesis*, an intellectual virtue that allows for proper judgment in each circumstance.
- This balance is also not synonymous with mediocrity. It is an active expression of practical wisdom, where impulses and emotions are governed to achieve a harmonious and virtuous life.
- Aristotle argues that virtue is acquired through habit: the repetition of correct actions consolidates a just and balanced character.

CLASSIC EXAMPLES OF THE GOLDEN MEAN

- Courage: the mean between cowardice (deficiency) and recklessness (excess).
- Generosity: the mean between stinginess and extravagance.
- Moderation: the mean between insensitivity and indulgence.

The theory of the golden mean is one of Aristotle's great contributions to ethics, as it teaches that a virtuous life requires discernment, adaptation, and constant practice to find the balance between extremes.

THE RELEVANCE OF ARISTOTELIAN THOUGHT

More than 2,500 years have passed since Aristotle proposed these ideas, and yet they remain relevant. We have improved in terms of comfort and life expectancy, but when it comes to the pursuit of happiness, virtue, or political justice, it seems we are still debating the same issues.

Aristotle's philosophy, like Plato's, is hardly surpassable. The mistake of our modern society is to think that we already know everything and that we do not need to return to the classics. On the contrary, the first thing any civilized person should do is consider what the great geniuses of the past thought before forming an opinion. Ignoring their legacy is, in words Aristotle would likely agree with, a sign of barbarism.



QUIZ

1. According to Aristotle, what is the primary foundation of true and perfect happiness for a human being?

- A. The accumulation of wealth and achieving social prestige.
- B. The enjoyment of physical pleasures and sensory experiences.
- C. The contemplative activity of the intellect and living according to reason.
- D. Achieving a state of freedom from all laws and social norms.

2. What is the concept of the 'Golden Mean' in Aristotle's ethical framework?

- A. A state of mediocrity where one avoids making any significant choices.
- B. A fixed, mathematical midpoint that is the same for every person in every situation.
- C. A balance point between two vicious extremes, one of excess and one of deficiency.
- D. The complete suppression of all passions and impulses to live a life of pure logic.

3. In the context of the Golden Mean, Aristotle identifies courage as the virtue between which two vices?

- A. Insensitivity and indulgence.
- B. Stinginess and extravagance.
- C. Cowardice and recklessness.
- D. Barbarism and demagoguery.

4. What was Aristotle's primary concern with an uncontrolled democratic system of government?

- A. It would inevitably be controlled by the wealthiest citizens.
- B. It risked degenerating into demagoguery, where emotions overrule reflection.
- C. It would fail to create any laws, leading to a state of barbarism.
- D. It was an outdated system compared to his teacher Plato's ideal republic.

5. According to Aristotle, how is a virtuous character primarily developed and strengthened?

- A. Through a single moment of profound philosophical understanding.
- B. By being born with an innately good and balanced nature.



- C. Through the consistent repetition of correct and just actions.
- D. By isolating oneself from society to focus solely on contemplation.

6. What role does 'phronesis' (prudence) play in achieving the Golden Mean?

- A. It is the emotional intuition that helps one feel the correct action.
- B. It is the intellectual virtue that allows for proper judgment in each circumstance.
- C. It is another name for the virtue of moderation.
- D. It is the tendency to always choose the safest, least risky option.

7. How did Aristotle distinguish between a 'legal' and a 'legitimate' ruler?

- A. A legal ruler follows the law perfectly, while a legitimate ruler is popular with the people.
- B. A ruler is legal if they attain power lawfully, but only legitimate if they govern for the common good.
- C. There is no difference; any ruler who comes to power legally is, by definition, legitimate.
- D. A legal ruler is one who creates new laws, while a legitimate ruler only enforces existing ones.

8. Which social class did Aristotle believe was best suited to govern in his proposed balanced political model?

- A. The rich, because they are well-educated and have time for politics.
- B. The poor, because they represent the majority of the population.
- C. The philosophers and intellectuals, as in Plato's Republic.
- D. The middle classes, because they could maintain a just mean and avoid excesses.

ANSWERS

- 1. C
- 2. C
- 3. C
- 4. B
- 5. C
- 6. B
- 7. B



8. D

WRITING

Instructions:

After having seen the above, take 5–10 minutes to write a short reflection (about half a page).
You can respond to the following prompts:

1. How would you define happiness in your own words after today's discussion?
2. What is one thing you learned from your partner's perspective about happiness?
3. Do you think happiness is a goal to pursue directly, or something that comes as a result of living in a certain way? Explain your reasoning.
4. What small action will you try this week to bring more happiness into your life or someone else's?

Optional Extension (Creative Choice):

- Write a short poem, letter, or story that expresses what happiness feels like for you. 120-180 words.

HELP

Possible Writing Ideas

1. Defining Happiness

- Start: "For me, happiness means..."
- Explain with one or two examples (a memory, a daily activity, or a personal value).
- Conclude with how they think people can find more happiness in life.

2. A Personal Experience of Happiness

- Describe a specific moment or event that made them feel deeply happy.
- Explain why it was meaningful: friendship, achievement, family, or personal growth.
- Reflect on whether happiness comes from similar experiences often.

3. Inside vs. Outside Happiness

- Argue whether real happiness comes more from inner attitudes (like gratitude, peace, optimism) or outer circumstances (success, wealth, relationships).
- Give a personal example for support.
- Conclude with their own balanced view.

4. Happiness in Difficult Times



- Tell about a time when life was not easy but they still felt moments of happiness.
- Explain what helped them find joy despite challenges (friends, hope, small victories).
- Reflect on what this shows about the nature of happiness.

5. Happiness as a Goal

- Discuss whether happiness should be the main goal of life or if other things (such as purpose, kindness, or growth) are just as important.
- Give examples or compare ideas learned from the partner in class.
- End with their personal conclusion.

How do we check it?

Criteria	Excellent (3)	Good (2)	Needs Improvement (1)
Reflection Depth	Shows deep and thoughtful understanding of happiness with clear personal insights and examples.	Provides some insightful ideas but may lack detail or depth in parts.	Very basic or superficial reflection with little personal engagement.
Connection to Partner's Ideas	Clearly explains what was learned from partner's perspective with specific reference.	Mentions partner's perspective but without detail.	Does not reference partner's ideas.
Clarity & Organization	Writing is clear, well-structured, and easy to follow. Ideas flow logically.	Writing is understandable but may be somewhat disorganized.	Writing is unclear or difficult to follow.
Language Use	Uses appropriate vocabulary, grammar, and sentence structures with few or no errors.	Some errors, but overall meaning is clear.	Frequent errors that interfere with clarity.
Creativity (Optional Extension)	Expresses happiness through poem, story, or letter in a vivid, original way.	Creative attempt is made but somewhat limited in expression.	No creative effort or very



Criteria	Excellent (3)	Good (2)	Needs Improvement (1)
			minimal attempt.

